

PTI

REPEAT SWEEP Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel (centre) with other BJP leaders in Gandhinagar, June 4

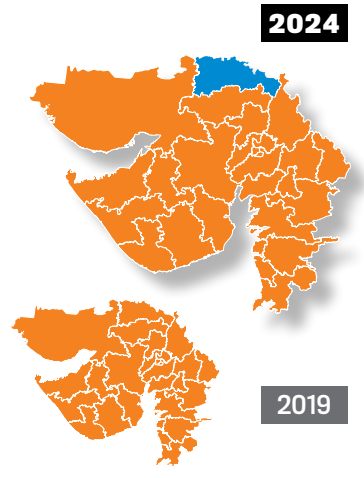
A BLIP CALLED BANASKANTHA

The north Gujarat constituency played spoiler in the BJP's hat-trick of a perfect score. The party must also guard against voter fatigue

By **Jumana Shah**

The BJP maintained its dominance in Gujarat on expected lines, albeit with a loss in one seat—Banaskantha—in north Gujarat. Not the ideal outcome for a party that strives for perfection in the prime minister and home minister's home state, a script that had been unwavering in the past two elections, when the BJP won all 26 seats. Assured of that unassailability, the ruling party had set an even more ambitious target—to win each seat by 500,000 votes. Three seats answered to that call—Amit Shah in Gandhinagar, C.R. Paatil in Navsari and Vadodara, where a new candidate, Hemang Joshi, was contesting. Notably, Rajkot candidate Parshottam Rupala won by a margin of 484,260 votes, despite his comment about Rajput maharajas kicking off a right royal storm, with the Kshatriya community demanding his withdrawal and launching an anti-BJP campaign that reverberated beyond the state. Post the result, BJP spokesperson Yamal Vyas said Kshatriyas did not vote against the BJP. A native of Amreli, Rupala had been fielded from Rajkot. Similarly, Union minister Mansukh Mandaviya, from Bhavnagar, was asked to contest from Porbandar, a seat he won by 383,360 votes. While the BJP and the Congress saw minor reductions in their respective vote shares, new entrant Aam Aadmi Party (AAP)—which contested in two seats as part of the INDIA bloc—got a 2.7 per cent vote share.

The BJP's continued success owes to PM Narendra Modi's enduring popularity, as well as its dominance over all local governance bodies, which allows them access to households. However, Gujarat's voting pattern have begun to show some dissonance, indicating that shows that concerns like inflation, sidelining of senior BJP leaders and corruption need to be addressed. BJP sources confide that disgruntlement within the party, induction and rewarding of Congress turncoats at the cost of loyal cadres and voter fatigue have exposed some chinks in the BJP's Gujarat armour. It showed up this time in Banaskantha, where the Congress candidate, 48-year-old Geniben Thakor, a two-time MLA from Vav, won with a slim margin of 30,406 votes. Thakor's victory is credited to her reputation as a hard-working leader; she also crowdfunded her campaign. Congress spokesperson Manish Doshi said, "'Banas ni ben' will be 'Gujarat ni ben' in Parliament...real issues of people will be raised in Delhi." The win in Banaskantha has infused new energy in a party that did not open its account at all in 2014 and 2019. The Congress was expected to win two more seats—Patan and Anand—while a tough fight was anticipated in Bharuch. The BJP won all three with slim margins. The AAP was routed by 85,696 votes despite its Bharuch candidate and MLA Chaitar Vasava's popularity among tribal youth. In the end, the BJP fell one short of a clean sweep, but not before the Gujarat voter gently reminded it that their loyalty cannot be taken for granted. ■



TOTAL LOKSABHA SEATS 26

	BJP	CONG	AAP
2024	25 (61.9%)	1 (31.2%)	0 (2.7%)
2019	26 (62.2%)	0 (32.1%)	- (-%)

Vote share in ( )